

How did prosperity change the lives of the American people in the 1950s?

The 1950s in America were a time of remarkable prosperity that significantly transformed the lives of many Americans, bringing about changes that affected people's daily lives, work, and social structures in profound ways.

One of the most visible impacts of this prosperity was a dramatic improvement in the standard of living. By 1960, the average American had a standard of living three times higher than that of the average Briton. This newfound affluence meant that more families could afford modern conveniences and luxuries. For example, the number of households with a television skyrocketed from 3 million in 1945 to 55 million by 1960, allowing families to enjoy entertainment and stay informed in ways previously unimaginable. Car ownership also soared, with the number of cars on the road increasing from 25 million to 60 million during the same period, giving people more freedom and mobility.

We need to remember that these figures are averages – there were some groups who did not share in the rising prosperity and whose lives were not changed at all by it. Some 35% of the population still lived below the poverty line. Marginalized groups such as Mexican and Hispanic Americans, Native Americans, and many African Americans did not experience the same level of affluence. [...]

However, many Americans did prosper during the 1950s. The economic boom particularly benefited the middle class – this era is often called the 'Golden Age' of the American middle class. The period saw an increase in 'white-collar' jobs, which offered more stable and better-paying employment opportunities. With higher wages, better working conditions, and more leisure time secured by strong unions, the middle class enjoyed a level of financial security and comfort that allowed them to invest in their future and enjoy life more fully. As a result, families spent more on consumer goods, vacations, and leisure activities. Meanwhile, the prosperity of the 1950s allowed teenagers, for the first time, to have their own spending money, which they used on fashion, music, and entertainment, contributing to the rise of a 'youth culture'.

The rise of the suburbs was another significant change. By 1960, a quarter of Americans lived in suburban areas, and more than 60% owned their homes. This suburban boom provided families with more space, cleaner environments, and a sense of community. The bread-winner now commuted to their place of work on the newly-built Interstate Highway System. The move to the suburbs also fostered a lifestyle centered around family life and home ownership, which became symbols of success and stability.

Prosperity led to consumerism, which became a defining feature of American life in the 1950s. The culture of consumption involved a change of attitude, as well as just an increase in possessions. The opening of the first shopping mall in 1956 popularised shopping as a leisure activity. Popular TV shows like 'Father Knows Best' depicted idealized suburban lives, reinforcing the notion that happiness was tied to middle class affluence and morality ... and advertisers were all too happy to sell the idea that happiness and success were linked to owning the latest products. Prosperity changed the 'American Dream' from a vision of freedom, equality, and prosperity for all for a materialistic hunt for affluence and continuous personal and national economic growth.